Mentoring Individuals in Their Practice: Inquiry and "Vipassana Out Loud," Part One #1

MINDFULNESS MEDITATION TEACHER CERTIFICATION PROGRAM

Overview of Practice Meeting

The purpose of a practice meeting is to support students in their formal practice of mindfulness and heart meditations. The broad goals are to inspire practice, to give clarity about how to practice, to share your understanding of teachings that are context for practice, to build students' confidence in their capacity to practice, and their faith in their innate wisdom and compassion.

DOMAINS OF EXPLORATION AND INQUIRY

Current Practice Learn the frequency, duration, what exactly they are doing. It is important here to ascertain if they understand the basic instructions, if they are using anchors, what anchors they are using, how they work with thoughts, and how they work with emotional difficulties.

Aspiration What is their deepest intent or aspiration in practicing?

Attitude in Approaching Sitting Are they dutiful, eager, driven, anxious, judgmental, sincere, or joyful?

How It's Going What are their current challenges and fruits?

AREAS FOR GUIDANCE, CLARIFICATION AND FINE-TUNING PRACTICE

Broad Type of Practice Would they be best served by emphasizing Vipassana, concentration, Metta, forgiveness, compassion, or some combination?

Structure of Practice Would any adjustment in time of practice, duration, location, or physical way of sitting be beneficial?

Attitude Exploring aspiration as practice

"How To's" of Practice If necessary, review basic instructions

Quality of Attention Recognizing if they might balance their energy with arousing factors of attention (mindfulness, investigation, interest, wise effort) or stabilizing factors (mindfulness, concentration, tranquility, equanimity)

Other Skillful Means Use of different anchor(s); reflecting on intention; developing refuge/resource anchors for safety, love—e.g., image, hand on heart, breathing with, taking breaks, leaning in

Clarifying Skillful Means Versus Choiceless Awareness Non-doing

Mentoring Individuals in Their Practice: Inquiry and "Vipassana Out Loud," Part One #2

MINDFULNESS MEDITATION TEACHER CERTIFICATION PROGRAM

Seeking Clarification

When mentoring students, the process of seeking clarification expresses your interest and enables you to more fully understand their experiences. It also helps the student to articulate and grasp more deeply their own experience.

SUMMARIZING, REFLECTING, OR OFFERING BACK

One element in seeking clarification is summarizing, reflecting, or offering back to the student what you have heard them say, and checking to see if you understood it correctly:

"I just heard you say that when you shift your attention away from thoughts and pay attention to your body, you start to feel very anxious, almost panicky. Is that it?"

"So, you're saying the worst part for you is how you're judging yourself?"

This reflecting back is done when the person initially presents their question or situation, and at other junctures when it feels appropriate. While you don't have to mirror their words exactly, it's helpful to offer back some of the same language you are hearing.

OPEN QUESTIONS

A second element in seeking clarification is asking nonjudgmental open questions.

The most effective questions start with "what" or "how." You might also find questions with "when" or "where" useful. While "why" can be helpful at times, it often leads into abstract thinking.

Open questions encourage students to be open and expand on their experience. In contrast, closed questions usually elicit a "yes" or "no" response, or a brief factual response.

Open Questions

When do you find you get most caught in anxious obsessing?
Where do you feel the anxiety in your body?
What is it that the frightened part of you is believing?
How does it feel to offer some kindness to that part of you?

Closed Questions

Do you get caught in anxious obsessing often?
Have you tried long, deep breathing to calm yourself?
When did you first explore working with obsessive thinking?
Have there been times in your life that you were relatively calm?
Do you see a link between obsessive thinking and when you're feeling fear of failure?

The process of clarifying does not always take the form of inquiry. You might say: "Please say more," or, "Please tell me more about that."

You might also ask for specific examples if it will help to ground what a student is expressing:

"I usually assume people are rejecting me."
Mentor: "What might be a recent example?"

"When I meditate, I always spiral into self-judgment."
Mentor: "Please tell me more; how did this happen recently? Can you describe it?"

OTHER GUIDELINES FOR SEEKING CLARIFICATION

Feel free to admit when you're not clear about what is being shared.

If you are checking to see if you understood something correctly, be prepared (and OK with!) being corrected.

Take the role of an ally (caring co-exploration, seeking understanding together).

Refrain from giving advice or sharing from your own experience.

Keep in touch with your deep intention to understand and communicate care and interest.